

1995

HAIR-TRIGGER

◀◀ REWIND

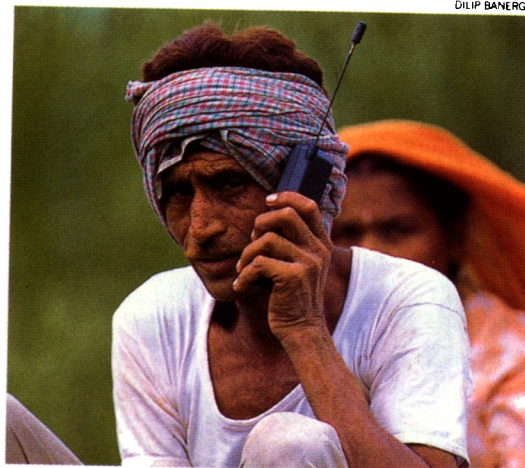
When the flames died down, reducing the Sufi shrine of Charar-e-Sharif and some 200 buildings near it to a smouldering heap, it was 3 a.m. on May 11. Soon, under the cover of darkness, the 40 militants holed up in the shrine, including Pakistani commander 'Major' Mast Gul, escaped into town. In the close-quarter fighting that followed, 27 militants were killed with no civilian dead, but the incident set back the leadership by many steps on the hard road to normalcy.

PRASHANT PANJIAR

RAIL OF BLOOD

On August 20, the superfast Purushottam Express, travelling at over 100 kmph, collided with the stationary Kalindi Express near Ferozabad, killing 348 people, in the second worst rail disaster in the country's history. The accident once again put the spotlight on the Railways' shocking disregard for basic safety norms.

DILIP BANERJEE



FUTURE CALLS

The mobile phone revolution came to India on September 27 as Hutchison Max Telecom became the first service provider to begin operations in the country.

FIRST CUT

Mayawati, then a member of the Rajya Sabha, became Uttar Pradesh's first Dalit chief minister on June 3. But she rode roughshod over the bureaucracy

and the BJP, transferring officials placing Dalits in key posts, and accumulating corruption charges, until BJP withdrew support to bring her tumultuous 136-day rule to an end.

◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

On December 23, over 400—mostly children—died in a fire incident in the midst of a school function in Dabwali, Haryana. The shocking incident raised questions about fire safety conditions in India.